AI Agents aren’t a tool decision. They’re an Operating Model decision.

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The conversation around AI in the enterprise is starting to shift. For the past few years, much of the discussion has focused on one question, **what AI tools should we adopt?** But that question is becoming too narrow. The more strategic question is like **how should the enterprise evolve when people, traditional software and AI agents begin to share the execution of work?** This is no longer just a technology decision. It has implications for enterprise architecture, operating models, security and ultimately, the capabilities of the organization.

From an Enterprise Architecture perspective, one way to frame this is through three layers:

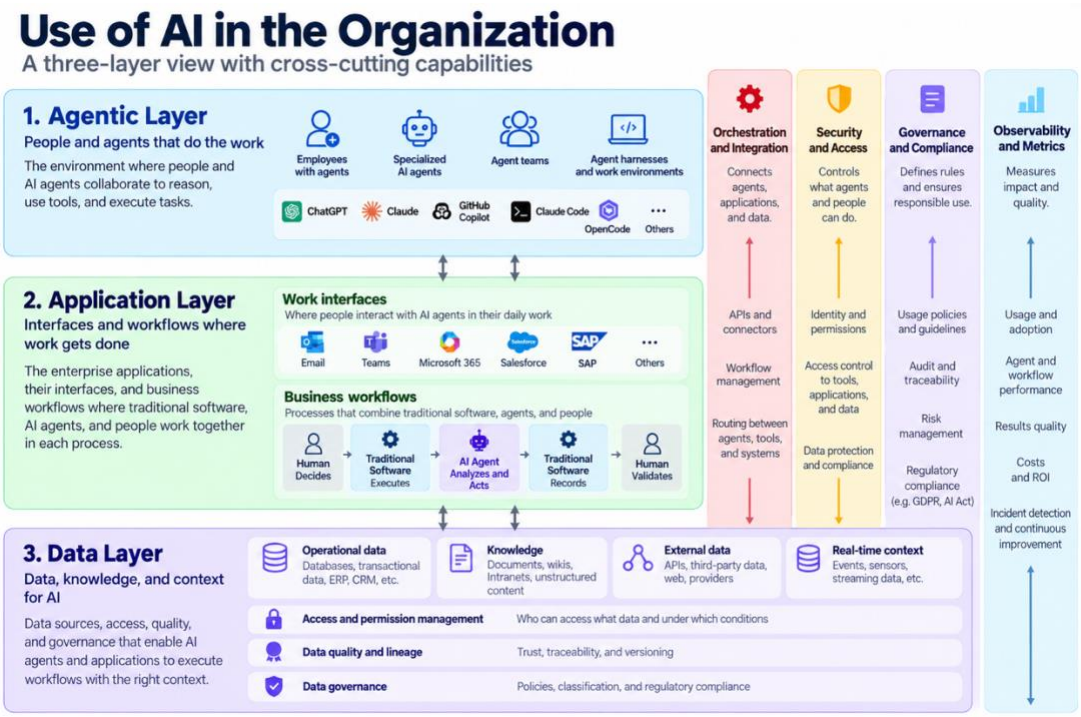


Figure 1: Layered approach towards the use of AI in the organization

The Agentic Layer: Agents and their harnesses are moving AI beyond a conversational interface. They introduce the ability to reason about tasks, use tools, access organizational knowledge and execute actions with varying degrees of autonomy. Everybody learns in this process, the person, the agent and the organization.

The Application Layer: Here, it is important to distinguish applications from the **workflows that run across them**. ERP, CRM, email, collaboration platforms and enterprise applications are not necessarily going away. What may change significantly is how work flows between them. A single workflow may increasingly look like this:

That creates an important architectural and **business decision**: determining which capabilities should remain deterministic, which can be delegated to agents and which should remain under human control.

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The Data Layer: Agents need data, knowledge and context. But simply giving them access to information is not enough. Organizations need to determine **what agents can access, how that information can be used, what actions they are authorized to perform and under what level of accountability and control.**

Across all three layers, several capabilities become strategic: **orchestration, identity, security, governance, traceability, observability and cost control.**

But the conversation needs to move beyond architecture, because for executive teams, the question should not be how many agents to deploy or which platform to adopt, it should be **which business capabilities do we want to transform, what operating model do we want to build and what combination of people, software and agents will allow us to do that securely, sustainably and at scale?** That also changes how we should think about technology investment.

> **For executive teams** the conversation should be around which business capabilities wanted to be transformed and what operating model is necessary to be built to support that shift.

Not everything currently performed by software should become agentic. There will be areas where agents create capabilities that did not previously exist, others where they

significantly augment existing capabilities and many where deterministic software will remain the better solution. The advantage, therefore, may not belong to the organizations that deploy the most agents, it may belong to those with the discipline to decide **where to use them, where not to use them and how to evolve their architecture and operating model, so that people, software and agents can operate as one coherent system.**

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